train into a city and each aeroplane leaving the country. While it is difficult to quantify migrations before the late 19th century with great precision, the historical accounts narrated in this chapter show that they were substantive for specific regions and time periods.[93] They were almost always linked with global migrations—in prehistoric times with the human journey out of tropical Africa, in medieval times with the march across the arid zones of the world, and in modern times, in sync with the waves of globalization.

However, until recently, one of the peculiarities about Indian migration was that you saw migrants everywhere except in the data collected by the Census and National Sample Surveys. Official surveys asked people whether they were migrants, defined so if they were outside their usual place of residence for at least six months. Such an approach omitted many circular migrants who moved for shorter spells or whose residential sites were often not enumerated in the destination region, or those who reported themselves as non-migrants rather than return migrants in the source region.[94] It also undercounted female migrants for work as they would report themselves as migrants for marriage. As a result, migration escaped the attention of policy makers under incorrect assumptions of low spatial mobility in India.

Researchers have only now begun to evaluate critically the official statistical databases and have derived migration estimates that are several times higher than earlier estimates. Migration rates at the all-India level are no longer considered to be exceptionally low and are astoundingly high in many parts of India. The key to understanding migration in India is by looking at the reason and duration of migration.

One important reason for migration is ‘forced migration’ due to involuntary displacements caused by natural disasters, wars, riots, persecutions and development projects. The numbers for this kind of migration are difficult to come by in surveys, though in Chapter 5 we will observe that since Independence, more than 40 million Indians have been estimated to have moved in this manner. The number of internally displaced persons, and refugees in India from Tibet, Sri Lanka, Afghanistan, Myanmar and a few other countries currently stands at close to 1 million